

Mukhtar Saad Shehata

Affiliated Researcher from November 2021 until December 2022.

Mukhtar Shehata is an Egyptian freelance researcher and writer. He holds an MA degree in African Studies, Indigenous Peoples, and Black Cultures from the Universidade do Estado da Bahia. He is the author of several novels, short stories, and research essays, and co-author with Samuli Schielke of the monograph *Shared Margins: An Ethnography with Writers in Alexandria after the Revolution*, which was recently published in the *ZMO Studien* series. As a guest of EUME and ZMO in Berlin in 2021-22, he works on a new research project on changes in the lives of Egyptian women and the rise of the “semi-city” after the 2011 revolution.

Samuel Schielke und Mukhtar Saad Shehata (Berlin) The dream of stability and the semi-cities: How conservative strivings transform society between Egypt and its diasporas Rural-urban and international migrations in and from the Global South are often socially conservative projects: strivings to actualise conventional ways and ideas of a good life. They are grounded in the imagination and practice of what in Arabic is widely referred to as “a normal life” (hayah 'adiya), “a life worthy of humans” (hayat bani adamin), or “stability” (istiqrar). Migrants from northern Egypt travel to Egyptian cities, western Europe, and Arab Gulf states where they work to build or maintain a normal, settled adulthood at home. A key effort of theirs is to build houses in their regions of origin. These houses unite strivings for moral and material comfort, upward social mobility, and rootedness in local communities. And yet in the process, their dream of a good, normal life at home appears to be unsettling itself by the virtue of its own success. This becomes evident in transformations of social status, gender roles, and built environment in rural areas that are transforming into “semi-cities” where rural traditions and urban consumerist lifestyle intermingle. Especially in families that seek to combine urban lifestyles with residence in the village, women establish new tactical avenues of action. A new form of life takes shape, one that seeks to reproduce patriarchal ideals but at the same time undermines them. Samuli Schielke is a social and cultural anthropologist writing about contemporary Egypt and the Gulf region. He is a senior research fellow at Leibniz-Zentrum Moderner Orient (ZMO), and author of *The Perils of Joy* (2012), *Egypt in the Future Tense* (2015), *Migrant Dreams* (2020), and *Shared Margins* (2021). Mukhtar Shehata is an Egyptian writer and independent researcher. He holds an MA degree in African Studies, Indigenous Peoples, and Black Cultures from the Universidade do Estado da Bahia. He is the author of several novels, short stories, and research essays. He is currently an affiliated fellow at Leibniz-Zentrum Moderner Orient (Berlin).

Short Film:

<https://www.samuli-schielke.de/theotherside/>

Lecture: The Secret Capitals: The Egyptian Countryside after the Revolution

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bnqH-nsLUKg&t=52s>